

Impact Low · Difficulty Medium · Misuse risk Mistaking a softer tone for lower pressure, and still asking too many, too person

THE MOVE

Formula: observation or context + one soft question + autonomy release. -> That sounds like a lot. If one question is okay: what would be useful from me right now? -> I'm asking so I don't have to guess. What's the main constraint? Short ?

START HERE

Make one human comment, ask one soft question, then release the pressure: 'One question, and you can skip it: what changed?'

SAY THIS

Quick starters	"One question, and you can skip it: what changed?"
Warm and sensitive	"I'm curious, but I don't want to pry. What's the public version?"
Diagnosis without bl...	"I'm trying to understand the system, not assign blame. What constraint mattered most?"
Async and two-optio...	"Answer whichever is easiest: timing, budget, or scope?"
Repair and softening	"That came out like an interrogation. Let me slow down."
When you must ask d...	"I need to ask this directly for safety, not blame. Are you at risk right now?"

AVOID

- Safety-critical facts that must be established quickly. Ask clearly and directly.
- Formal investigations, audits, safeguarding, medical triage, or legal procedures that need a documented sequence. Frame the process openly: 'I need to ask these in order for safety.'
- Structured questioning the person has already consented to, such as an interview or intake. Stay warm, but don't obscure the process.

REMEMBER

One question lands better than five.